



BEST BUY
digit
APRIL 2007

Leadtek Winfast PVR2000
The Undisputed King

The Compro VideoMate TV Gold⁺II and Leadtek Winfast PVR2000 are bundled with software that consist of premium video editing software like Ulead's DVD MovieFactory and VideoStudio. Pinnacle PCTV Pro PCI is the next best, with Pinnacle Studio QuickStart 10—a lite version of their deluxe software.

Windows Media Center Edition and Vista Media Center Readiness

Windows Media Center and Vista Media Center have the same basic requirements, and most of the TV-Tuners cannot not fulfil these. The Leadtek Winfast and Pinnacle are the only ones that qualify in both the above criteria, and are therefore future-proof. The Pinnacle is only Windows XP MCE ready card.

Performance

Ease of Installation and Use

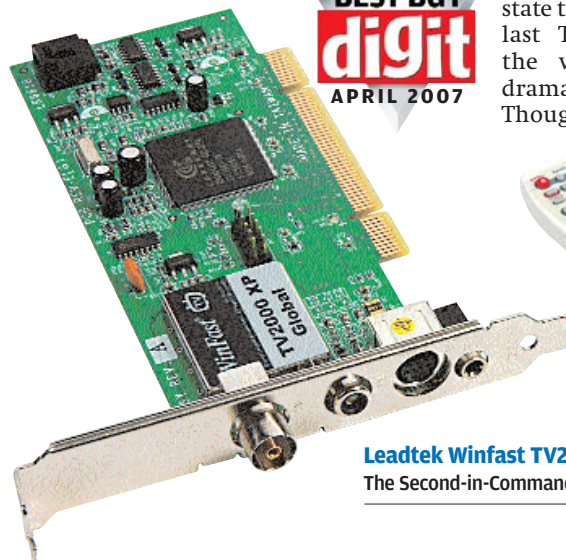
Installing the TV-Tuners was very straightforward. Driver installation was also hassle-free, save for the PixelView cards, which took a considerable amount of time because they had drivers for too many cards on the same CD.

Some PVR software are very elementary in appearance. A good example would be the one that came with the Tech-Com TV-Tuners, and also the HonestTech PVR that comes with the PixelView PlayTV Pro 2. Some such as the ones from Hauppauge, Leadtek Winfast, and Pinnacle not only have all the functionality but also a beautiful interface.

The Field Tests

A TV-Tuner is expected to be able to detect all the channels a cable operator has to offer. Of the 90 channels that our cable operator offers, the Compro VideoMate TV Gold⁺II, Leadtek Winfast cards, and the Pinnacle PCTV Stereo PCI could detect 87; most of the other cards were somewhere behind in the 80s. The Tech-Coms were far behind everyone, managing to detect just 68. We expected no card to reach 90, as we had weakened the signal strength to a great extent. A card that manages over 80 is just about as good as any card can be. It is therefore no surprise that fine-tuning was necessary for all the TV-Tuner cards.

BEST BUY
digit
APRIL 2007



Leadtek Winfast TV2000 XP Global
The Second-in-Command

Visual quality is an important parameter for judging a TV-Tuner card. We would like to state that compared to the last TV-Tuner shootout, the visual quality has dramatically improved. Though the chipsets are

Windows Vista: Media Center

Vista, the latest avatar of the world's most popular operating system, has been released. For those of you eagerly waiting to hear about the much-touted Media Center in Windows Vista, there is good as well as bad news. We shall go with the bad news first.

If you expected Vista Media Center would be more generous in its acceptance of TV-Tuner types, you are in for a disappointment: it has exactly the same requirements as Windows XP Media Center Edition. The TV-Tuner must have certain features such as a listed at <http://www.microsoft.com/windowsxp/mediacenter/partners/dfw/tvtunercardsreq.msp>, which is niche. Not only are such TV-Tuners expensive, they are really hard to find, especially in India.

The good news is that Vista Media Center is extremely easy to set up. It has Wizards—very similar to those in its predecessor—that guide you through the setup process, and everything is well-explained. Vista Media Center is seamlessly integrated with the OS and therefore appears as an extension of it. It is not just another PVR software: it is a whole multimedia entertainment suite that

includes a music player, DVD player, and so on.

Unlike Windows XP Media Center Edition, which only comes bundled with Media Center PCs and cannot be bought as a separate OS, you can pick up your copy of Vista off the shelf. Compatible TV-Tuners, such as one from Hauppauge, are already appearing in the market, and it will not be long before their prices go down.

Microsoft launched the MCE program early last year, and has already made available features such as EPG (Electronic Program Guide). An EPG provides you not only informative program schedules for various channels, but also lets the Media Center schedule recordings of programmes when you aren't around. Being seamlessly integrated, it has one of the best interfaces you may see in PVRs (Personal Video Recorders), and it also performs remarkably well.

One can record HDTV broadcasts. Unfortunately, neither this broadcast standard nor the supporting TV-Tuners will be available in India at least for the next few years. All of the Media Center can be controlled using the remote bundled with the TV-Tuner.